

Acolyte Customary

Anglican Church of the Holy Cross

The primary job of the lay ministers known as acolytes is to assist priests (and deacons) in the celebration of the Eucharist and other liturgical services. Acolytes also lead the congregation in prayers, responses, and actions. People are watching you for cues on what to do!

Remember to always be inconspicuous. Fold hands when not holding something. Move slowly and reverently. If you make a mistake don't call attention to it and move on to the next right thing.

Be at least 15 minutes early. Vest in cassock and surplice unless otherwise instructed.

What follows may be done by one person but is often divided among two or more:

- **Before the service**
 - **Check the credence table** for sufficient communion bread, wine, and water. Make sure the lavabo bowl and towel are present. Check that the tabernacle key is either on the altar or the credence table.
 - **Light the altar candles** if they are not already lit. If you are by yourself, light the Epistle side first (*the Gospel candles never burn alone*). Light from the center out (*think of a curtain opening before a play*).
 - **Extra credit:** Look over the Epistle or lesson and figure out how to introduce and conclude it if the lector doesn't show.
 - **Return to the vestry**, note any special instructions and say the Preparation with the Celebrant.
- **At the Procession**
 - **Stand** just inside the nave, with the processional cross, through the introduction to the first hymn.
 - **Start the procession** when the congregation starts singing.
 - **Pause briefly** and bow slightly at the Sanctuary step. Never genuflect when carrying the cross.
 - **Post the cross** in its stand near the credence table. Find your hymnal and sing the remainder of the first hymn.

- **The Pro Anaphora** (aka the Ante Communion or the Liturgy of the Word)
 - **Kneel** through the collect of the day; sing (or say) the *Kyries* or answer the *Decalogue*.
 - **Stand** and face the Lector for the reading of the Epistle or lesson, or
 - **If you are reading**, take the Altar Book off its stand, step down, and read the Epistle or lesson from the communion rail in front of the Epistle corner of the Altar, then replace the book on the stand.
 - **Go up the altar step**, take the book and the stand off the Altar, turn by the center, step off the Altar step, bow toward the altar from the center, then step up and place the book and stand on the Gospel side of the Altar, angled so that it can be read from the center. NEVER walk backward. Return to your place if you are on the Epistle side, bowing as you pass the center of the Altar.
 - **Stand** facing the Gospeller (Celebrant or Deacon) for the reading of the Gospel, making the responses before and after.
 - **Face East** and join in reciting the Creed. Genuflect at the *Incarnatus*.
 - **Sit** for the notices.
 - **Stand** to sing the sermon hymn.
 - **Sit** for the sermon.
- **The Offertory**
 - **Bring the bread box** or ciborium to the Celebrant (or Deacon) at the Epistle corner of the Altar. Return it to the credence and
 - **Bring the cruets**, with the stoppers removed and handles out, wine in your right hand, water in your left.
 - **Hand over the wine cruet** and immediately switch the water from your left hand to your right (*always hand over the cruets with your right hand and take them back with your left*).
 - **Receive the wine cruet** in your left hand.
 - **Hold the water cruet** for the Celebrant's blessing, then hand it over, and immediately switch the wine from your left hand to your right.
 - **Receive the water cruet** in your left hand and return the cruets to the credence.
 - **As the Doxology starts**, take the receiving basin from the shelf under the credence, receive the offering from the ushers at the Chancel step, and take it to the Celebrant.
 - **Return to the credence**, take the lavabo bowl in your left hand, towel over your left arm, and water cruet by the handle in your right hand, to the Epistle corner.
 - **Pour water** over the Celebrant's hands. He will raise his hands slightly as a signal to stop. Offer the towel and remain there until he places it back over your arm. Then return the bowl, towel, and cruet to the credence.

- **The Prayer for the Church**
 - **Kneel** for the Prayer and continue kneeling through the Confession, Absolution, and Comfortable Words.
- **The Canon**
 - **Answer** the *Sursum Corda*.
 - **Ring the *Sanctus***, one bell as each “Holy” is sung or said. Always ring the bells gently (*think wind chime and not fire alarm*).
 - **Ring once** at the words “until His coming again.”
 - **Ring three times** at the Words of Institution over the bread (“do this in remembrance of me”), once at the Celebrant’s genuflection, elevation, and genuflection.
 - **Ring three times** at the Words of Institution over the wine (“drink it, in remembrance of me”), once at the Celebrant’s genuflection, elevation, and genuflection.
 - **Pray** the Lord’s Prayer and the Prayer of Humble Access.
 - **Ring three times** after the Prayer of Humble Access.
 - **Sing** (or say) the *Agnus Dei*.
- **The Communion**
 - **Make your communion**, then take the people’s offering off the altar and place it on the shelf under the credence.
 - **Sit** as far from the rail as practical during the communion of the people.
- **The Ablutions**
 - **Take the water cruets** by the handle, stopper removed, to the Epistle corner after the people have communicated and assist with the ablutions. Pour some water onto the paten and in the chalice as directed, then pour water over the Celebrant’s fingers as he holds them over the bowl of the Chalice. *Note that most priests use both wine and water for the ablutions. Father Newcomb uses water only.*

- **The Post Communion and Departing Procession**

- **Kneel** for the Prayer of Thanksgiving.
- **Stand** and face East to sing or say the *Gloria in Excelsis*.
- **Answer** the dismissal.
- **Kneel** for the blessing.
- **Take the processional cross** to the midst of the choir as the concluding hymn starts.
- **Turn by the right** as the Altar party reverences and lead the procession to the West door.
- **Post the cross** in its stand and return to the sacristy.
- **Extinguish the Altar candles** when the concluding hymn ends. If you are by yourself, extinguish the Gospel side first (*the Gospel candles never burn alone*). Extinguish from ends to the center (*think of a curtain closing after a play*).
- **Return to the vestry**, remove your vestments, and hang them neatly. Please point out any vestments that need attention or take them home and attend to them yourself.